

Gamehendge

A Companion Guide to Phish's Homemade Mythology

Built around "The Lizards" and the saga it lives inside

Music / Concept Album & Live Song Cycle

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Full detail (no spoiler limit — the saga is nearly 40 years old)

Quick Take

You asked about "The Lizards," but that song is one chapter of something much bigger, so this guide takes on the whole thing: Gamehendge, the fictional world Trey Anastasio invented for his 1988 college senior thesis and that Phish has been telling in pieces ever since. It is, basically, a homemade rock opera about a peaceful lizard people, a stolen book of secret wisdom, a tyrant named Wilson, and an ordinary retired colonel who steps through a magic door and tries to fix it all. He fails, more or less, and that failure is the point.

Here is why it is worth your time. Gamehendge is the closest thing in the jam-band world to The Who's Tommy or Rush's 2112: a single allegory carried across a full set of songs, performed live with spoken narration between numbers. It is also genuinely rare. Phish has played the complete saga only six times in roughly 35 years, which is exactly why fans treat catching one as a bucket-list event. And the ending is smarter and darker than the goofy character names let on. If you want one sentence to carry into it: this is a story about how knowledge can free people or enslave them, and about how the people who overthrow a tyrant have a nasty habit of becoming the next one.

Where It Came From: A College Thesis

Gamehendge began as homework. In July 1988, Trey Anastasio submitted his senior thesis at Goddard College in Vermont. It was titled "The Man Who Stepped Into Yesterday" (fans abbreviate it TMWSIY), and it was not a paper in the usual sense. It paired a written essay with an hour-long recording of original songs that told an epic story set in a made-up land called Gamehendge.

The seed predates the thesis. In 1986, Phish lyricist Tom Marshall handed Trey a poem that already named several characters who would become central: Colonel Forbin, the Famous Mockingbird, Rutherford the Brave, Tela, and a multibeast. That poem grew into the lyrics for one of the songs and, more broadly, into the mythology itself. So Gamehendge was collaborative from the start, not a solo flight.

The recording was charmingly lo-fi. Despite a common myth that Trey played everything himself, the full band tracked it: Anastasio (guitar, lead vocals, narration), Page McConnell (keys), Mike Gordon (bass), and Jon Fishman (drums). Trey later described the method:

"We learned The Man Who Stepped Into Yesterday and recorded it in our living room as quickly as possible. We recorded it onto one cassette, bounced it to another, and added the lyrics on top so the words come out of one speaker and the music out of the other."

— Trey Anastasio

That cassette was never officially released. For decades it circulated as a fan-traded bootleg, first on tape and later as internet files, which only deepened its holy-grail status. Trey has long

called Gamehendge "an unfinished project," because the band chose to record what became their debut album Junta rather than fully develop the saga.

The Story of Gamehendge

Here is the full arc, start to finish.

The land of Gamehendge is home to a gentle, simple race called the Lizards. High on the central mountain lives Icculus, a wise figure who long ago gave the Lizards the Helping Friendly Book, which holds "the ancient secrets of eternal joy and never-ending splendor." The book teaches one essential lesson: surrender to the flow. Living by it, the Lizards exist in harmony, free of greed and corruption.

Then comes Wilson, an outsider. He lives among the Lizards, studies the book, and then steals it and hides it away, declaring himself king. He enslaves the Lizards, clear-cuts their forest, and builds a walled city called Prussia, locking the Helping Friendly Book in the highest tower of his castle.

Enter our hero. Colonel Forbin is a bored, aging, retired colonel from Long Island who takes daily walks with his dog McGrupp. One day he notices a mysterious door he has never seen before, and after some hesitation, he steps through it into Gamehendge. There he meets an aging knight, Rutherford the Brave, who explains the world to him (this is where the song "The Lizards" lives). Forbin then meets Tela, a rebel fighter he promptly falls for, and rides a multibeast to the rebel base led by Errand Wolfe.

Seeking help, Forbin climbs the mountain to ask Icculus to intervene. Icculus delivers the saga's moral warning before acting:

"All knowledge, seeming innocent and pure, becomes a deadly weapon in the hands of avarice and greed."

— Icculus

Icculus sends the Famous Mockingbird to steal the book back from Wilson's tower. The Mockingbird succeeds. But here the story turns dark: rather than returning the book to the Lizards, the rebel leader Errand Wolfe seizes it for himself, ties the Mockingbird to a pole with glue and rubber bands, and sets himself up as the new tyrant. Wilson is assassinated (the deed is tied to the song "The Sloth"), and Forbin is left to realize the grim truth: the revolution simply swapped one despot for another. The cycle just repeats.

The Cast of Gamehendge

The character names are half the fun. A quick field guide:

Character	Who they are
Colonel Forbin	The protagonist. A retired, idealistic, slightly

	naive colonel from Long Island who steps through the door into Gamehendge with his dog.
McGrupp	Forbin's dog, and the namesake of the song "McGrupp and the Watchful Hosemasters."
Wilson	The villain. An outsider who stole the Helping Friendly Book and made himself tyrant-king of Prussia. His song draws the famous live crowd chant of "WIL-SON!"
Icculus	The wise author/deliverer of the Helping Friendly Book, living atop the mountain. The philosophical anchor of the whole saga.
The Lizards	The peaceful indigenous people of Gamehendge, "practically extinct from doing things smart people don't do."
Rutherford the Brave	An aging knight, one of the last Lizards, who explains the world to Forbin in the song "The Lizards."
Tela	A rebel fighter and Forbin's love interest, later revealed as a spy and killed. The thesis frames her as Forbin's opposite: "Everything that Tela is, Forbin isn't."
Errand Wolfe	The rebel leader who betrays the cause, seizes the book, and becomes the next tyrant. The pivot of the cynical ending.
The Famous Mockingbird	Icculus's agent, who retrieves the book from Wilson's tower.
The Sloth	A hired assassin (Wilson's killer).
AC/DC Bag	A robotic executioner. Its song depicts the execution of Mr. Palmer, Wilson's embezzling accountant.
The Multibeast / The Unit Monster	Creatures that appear in the spoken narration rather than as standalone songs: a mount Forbin rides, and Tela's bodyguard.

The Song Cycle (and Where "The Lizards" Fits)

The original 1988 thesis runs in nine parts, with short spoken narration between songs. The core sequence is: "The Man Who Stepped Into Yesterday" then "The Lizards" then "Tela" then "Wilson" then "AC/DC Bag" then "Colonel Forbin's Ascent" then "Fly Famous Mockingbird" then "The Sloth" then "Possum." Every song except "Possum" (written by early Phish guitarist Jeff Holdsworth) was composed by Anastasio.

Canon versus associated songs

This is the one genuinely fuzzy, fan-debated area, so here is the clean version. The nine songs above are the core canon — they are on the original tape. A wider circle of "associated" songs are Gamehendge-connected and often added to live Gamehendge sets but were not on the 1988 recording: The Divided Sky, Llama, McGrupp and the Watchful Hosemasters, Punch You in the Eye, Icculus, and Harpua, among others. The fun irony: "Icculus," named for a central character, has never actually been performed inside a full live Gamehendge.

"The Lizards" — the linchpin

Of all the songs, "The Lizards" does the most narrative work. One fan history calls it "the linchpin of the Gamehendge saga," the song where "nearly every disparate element of The Man Who Stepped Into Yesterday was made to cohere into a single, multifaceted narrative."

In the story, Forbin meets Rutherford the Brave in the streets of Prussia, and Rutherford sings his backstory: he is one of the Lizard people, a race nearly wiped out "from doing things smart people don't do." He is on a quest for the Helping Friendly Book and its secrets of eternal joy, the key being to "surrender to the flow." He notes that only one copy ever existed in Prussia, and that Wilson made merely possessing it a crime. The section ends with Rutherford diving into a raging river in full armor and being rescued by a mysterious creature, the Unit Monster.

A great deep-cut detail: the long instrumental coda of "The Lizards" was not originally written for Gamehendge at all. It came from a song called "If I Were a Dog," written for a children's musical titled "Gus the Christmas Dog," and was repurposed to soundtrack Rutherford's river rescue. The lyrics throughout are deliberately wordy, both to pull the listener in and to lay the groundwork for songs to come.

Themes and What Makes It Work

Strip away the lizards and robots and you get a tight political allegory with three big ideas.

Enlightenment versus tyranny. The Lizards live freely and simply by following the book; Wilson represents conquest, hierarchy, and the domination of nature (he clear-cuts the forest and builds a fortress-city). It is freedom-in-simplicity against power-and-greed.

Knowledge as a double-edged sword. The Helping Friendly Book is pure knowledge, and Icculus's warning is the moral core: the same wisdom that liberates the Lizards "becomes a deadly weapon in the hands of avarice and greed." Knowledge is not automatically good; it depends entirely on who holds it.

The cynical, cyclical ending. This is the part most casual listeners miss. Anastasio framed the conclusion deliberately: heroic action just replaces one despot (Wilson) with another (Errand Wolfe), suggesting that "no matter what action we take, the world remains filled with evil." The revolution eats itself. That anti-utopian streak is what elevates Gamehendge from a whimsical fantasy into a real piece of allegory.

In Phish culture, all of this gets compressed into a single rallying cry tied to Icculus: read the book. It started as a literacy joke and became a genuine fan creed.

Live and Rare: Performance History

Part of why Gamehendge is revered is that you almost never get to see it whole. Phish has performed the complete (or near-complete) saga only six times in roughly 35 years:

Date	Where / why it matters
3/12/1988	Nectar's, Burlington, VT — the first full live performance.
10/13/1991	Near-complete (omitted "The Lizards"); praised for especially clean audio.
3/22/1993	Crest Theatre, Sacramento, CA — often cited by fans as the purest "story" version.
6/26/1994	Municipal Auditorium, Charleston, WV.
7/8/1994	Great Woods, Mansfield, MA — the canonical official audio release.
12/31/2023	Madison Square Garden, NYC — the first complete cycle in 29 years, and the most elaborate ever staged.

Live, Gamehendge is delivered as a song cycle with Trey speaking the story in character between songs, transporting the room into the fictional land. Phish.net maintains an exhaustive archive transcribing every narrated Gamehendge story since 1986.

The 2023 MSG production finally delivered Trey's decades-old dream version. He had always wanted an elderly-woman narrator and fully orchestrated music under the narration. At MSG, actress and vocalist Annie Golden (*Orange Is the New Black*) narrated as the protagonist's grandmother, surrounded by costumed actors, dancers playing the Lizards, puppets for the Multibeast and McGrupp, and a giant Famous Mockingbird puppet flown over the crowd. After 35 years, the unfinished thesis got its full theatrical staging.

What You Might Not Know

- The whole thing is technically academic work: it earned Trey his Goddard College degree in 1988.
- For decades, the only complete Gamehendge anyone could officially own was the 7/8/1994 Great Woods show, finally released in August 2020 (after a 2020 "Dinner and a Movie" webcast). The 1988 thesis tape itself has still never been officially released.
- In the original recording, the spoken narration plays over background music pulled from sections of "Esther" and "McGrupp and the Watchful Hosemasters."

- The "Read the Book!" bit is real fan ritual: at the Dick's run in 2013, fans hired a small plane to fly a "READ THE BOOK" banner over the venue. The line "our children are old enough to read Icculus" is an intentional pun on "ridiculous."
- Gamehendge is not a Phish "Halloween musical costume." Those (starting with the Beatles White Album on 10/31/1994) are covers of other bands' full albums. Gamehendge is Phish's own original work.
- The mythology is still alive: Phish turned the Las Vegas Sphere into Gamehendge during a 2026 run, proving the saga remains central to the band's identity nearly four decades on.

Where to Start

If you are coming to this cold, here is the on-ramp.

Best overall entry point: the 12/31/2023 MSG performance, especially the official pro-shot 4K video cut available through LivePhish and YouTube. Modern audio and video, the complete narrative, and Broadway-scale staging make the story easy to follow in a way the old audience tapes never could.

For audio purists: the 7/8/1994 Great Woods show, the only officially released complete Gamehendge for decades and still the reference recording.

If you just want a few songs first: try "Wilson" (the villain's anthem, with the crowd chant), "AC/DC Bag," "The Lizards" (your original ask, and the story's exposition engine), "The Divided Sky" (an instrumental showcase), and "Possum." These are the most-played and most accessible doors into the mythology.

Why bother, in Phish terms: Gamehendge is the ideal on-ramp to the whole band, because it lets you hear both Phish modes at once — tight, through-composed writing and wide-open improvisation — held together by a story that keeps the jamming legible. Learn to enjoy Gamehendge and a regular two-set show makes a lot more sense.

If You Liked This

- **The Who — Tommy (1969) / Quadrophenia (1973)** — The rock opera that invented the form: a single allegorical story told across a full album and staged live. The most direct ancestor of what Gamehendge is doing.
- **Rush — 2112 (1976)** — A dystopia where a source of freedom (a rediscovered guitar) is suppressed by a totalitarian priesthood. Same DNA as the Helping Friendly Book versus Wilson, and Phish coverage cites 2112 directly as kin.
- **Genesis — The Lamb Lies Down on Broadway (1974)** — An ordinary protagonist (Rael) is pulled into a surreal symbolic underworld of strange creatures, much like Forbin stepping through the door into Gamehendge.

- **Coheed and Cambria — The Amory Wars** — The modern band most like Gamehendge: a frontman building an entire mythology that lives in both the music and written fiction, with recurring musical and lyrical motifs across the catalog.
- **David Bowie — The Rise and Fall of Ziggy Stardust (1972)** — The most accessible, song-forward pick: a fictional rock-messiah concept album for when the prog epics feel like too much.
- **Companion reading & listening** — The Phish Companion (Mockingbird Foundation) is the definitive fan reference, framed explicitly as the real-world Helping Friendly Book. Phish.net's Gamehendge and Helping Friendly Book FAQs are the best free deep-dives, and the "Undermine" podcast (narrated by lyricist Tom Marshall) covers exactly the early-decade era when Gamehendge was born.

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